

Commemorating the victory
Lepanto became a favorite subject for art all over Catholic Europe. This colorful Spanish version is painted on tiles. Between the Christian fleet (below) and the Ottomans (above), the huge Christian galleasses open fire at the start of the battle.

Crucially, the Venetians also provided six galleasses—large transport galleys turned into floating gun platforms. These were so unwieldy they had to be towed into position, but their massed guns packed a formidable punch. The presence of the galleasses was a surprise to the Ottomans. They were unsure of their tactical function, but soon found out as the thunder of the galleases' guns sent a savage hail of iron balls lashing into the galleys of the Ottoman center.

Although his fleet was thrown into disorder and two galleys had been sunk, Ali Pasha pressed on past the galleasses and through the fire from the galleys behind to engage the Christian center at close quarters. On the flanks a desperate battle was joined as the horns of the Turkish crescent attempted to outflank the Christian line. The Venetian galleys on the Christian left were close to shore, but some of Suluc's ships succeeded in rowing through shallow water beyond the edge of their line. Barbarigo's galleys skillfully backed to turn outward facing toward the shore, presenting their bow guns to the Ottoman ships, which were forced to turn to face them. A close-quarter mêlée ensued, in which Barbarigo was hit by an arrow and killed.

On the Christian right there was open water. Uluç Ali tried to outflank Doria's squadron, and Doria shifted further to the right to block him. This stretched the line between the Christian right and center. Choosing his moment, the wily Uluç Ali turned swiftly back to attack the straggling Christian galleys left behind by Doria's rightward move.

CHAOS AND BLOODSHED

By this stage, cloaked in a fog of gunpowder smoke, the battle was a scene of brutal slaughter. Everywhere galleys were locked together, soldiers fighting hand-to-hand on the decks with sword and pike. At the heart of the battle, Don John's flagship was boarded by janissaries—elite Ottoman infantry—from Ali Pasha's *Sultana*. The key to the outcome was the use of the reserve squadron made by Santa Cruz. Feeding his galleys into the action where they were needed, he enabled the Venetians on the left to hold and then put to flight their adversaries—many Ottoman troops escaping through the shallow water onto land.

Santa Cruz then decisively intervened in the struggle in the center. The *Sultana* was stormed and taken. Ali Pasha's severed head was displayed on a pike and the Ottoman standard struck from the mast. As the Ottoman center collapsed, fighting turned to massacre and plunder. Only Uluç Ali was able to extricate his galleys from the debacle, leading perhaps a sixth of the original force back to Constantinople.

The Ottomans quickly built a new fleet—their grand vizier bragged that the Christians had merely shaved the Ottoman beard that "would grow all the better for the razor." But Christian jubilation at victory in one of the largest sea battles ever fought was justifiable, for it stemmed the tide of Ottoman expansion that had threatened to engulf the whole Mediterranean.

Detailed contemporary record
The individual ships engaged in the center are clearly identifiable by their banners. At this early stage of the battle several of the Christian galleys have been boarded by Ottoman troops.